

Half the army's officer corps is still unhappy.



IT PAYS TO BE YOUNG: Courses at military academies will be well subscribed

poverty alleviation barely 11 paise reaches the intended beneficiary. A closer look at any sector will show the pathetic level of delivery. Take healthcare for instance. Sixty out of every 1,000 children born in the country die during birth which is worse than Sri Lanka and Vietnam. On education, the government spends over Rs 27,800 crore on primary education and literacy just at the Centre. Yet just in Uttar Pradesh there are over one million children out of school. Literacy levels for females languish at 53 per cent which means over 200 million women cannot write or read their name. The approach paper to the 11th

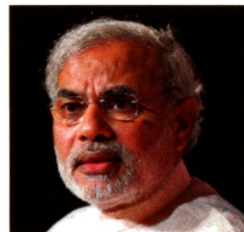
Plan puts it most succinctly. Just 28 per cent of our schools had electricity in 2005 and only about half had more than two teachers or two classrooms. Worse, only 40 per cent of primary schoolteachers were graduates and 30 per cent had not even completed higher secondary. Not surprisingly, a recent study which surveyed children who had completed four years of schooling, found that 38 per cent cannot read a small paragraph and 55 per cent cannot divide a three-digit number by a one-digit number. Interestingly the Sixth Pay Commission has made an effort to improve the wages of nurses, teachers and policemen. Good, but where is the mechanism to counter rampant absenteeism that plagues the sectors of health and education?

The pathetic state of performance is best illustrated in the delivery of ordinary government services ranging from death and birth certificates to land records. In many states like Maharashtra, the political regimes have had to outsource the functions of e-certification and e-governance to private service providers. If you are a taxpayer, you cannot expect refunds on time. If you apply for a passport, it could take anywhere between two months and four months depending on where you are located when by law it shouldn't take more than 21 days. To add insult to injury, the government from time to time institutes "tatkal" schemes where you are charged extra for delivery of services which are delayed because of the sloth. Acquiring a ration card, the ubiquitous Indian document of identity in some states, could take as long as six months unless of course the system was lubricated at points. If there is a saviour, it is IT which is triggering a sense of accountability within the system. Not surprisingly, the babudom would like it to crash under the weight of enquiries.

You could argue that benchmark indicators in sectors like healthcare and education also depend on the capital infused. But what is the bang we get for the buck we spend? If the finance minister has to repeat in budget after budget that outlays are not being translated into outcomes, obviously the delivery mechanism is failing. L.K. Jha, the doyen of Indian Civil Service, had once defined a bureaucrat as "a strange creature who sits on files, sleeps over reminders, eats his own words, turns a deaf ear to complaints and binds his hands and feet with red tape". That was at a meeting in Chennai in December 1985. Clearly things haven't changed much after two decades and three pay commissions. There are good officers but the odds seem stacked against them.

Nobody could have described the frustra-

GUJARAT



NARENDRA MODI
CHIEF MINISTER

"We have told the commission that the Centre should bear the burden of the recommendations. The state is not in a position to absorb it."

MAHARASHTRA



VILASRAO
DESHMUKH
CHIEF MINISTER

"We will study the details first. It is a policy decision by Maharashtra to implement what the Centre has recommended for its employees."